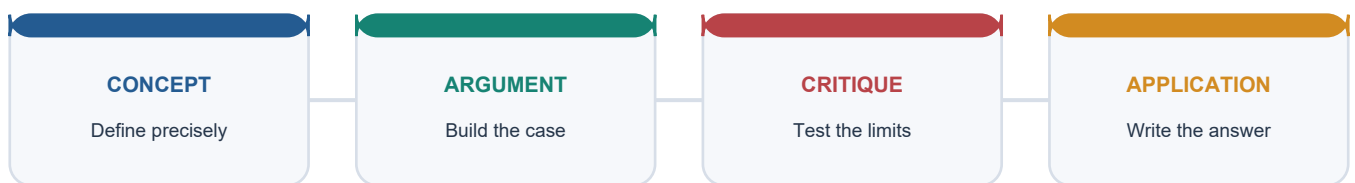


SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

State and Varna Society in the Age of the Buddha: Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / WORKBOOK INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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State and Varna Society in the Age of the Buddha: Solved Practice Workbook

Practice contract: exactly 32 original hard MCQs precede the PYQ audit; strict ABCD rotation repeats eight times; 128 option explanations and 32 traps are question-specific.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

32 ORIGINAL HARD MCQS

These are original questions, not UPSC PYQs. Correct keys rotate A -> B -> C -> D exactly eight times.

Q1

Which is the safest definition of the 'Age of the Buddha' for social history?

- A. A sixth-fifth century BCE core within a wider c. 600-200 BCE transformation
- B. A precisely dated lifetime recorded contemporaneously
- C. A uniform all-India century beginning in 600 BCE
- D. A synonym for the Mauryan Empire

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** The label is heuristic: political, textual and archaeological processes have overlapping but non-identical chronologies. [Q1-A: Historical horizon]
- **B:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the historical horizon evidence can establish. [Q1-B: Historical horizon]
- **C:** Its absolute wording erases regional, chronological or institutional variation. [Q1-C: Historical horizon]
- **D:** It projects a later Mauryan institution or chronology into a pre-Mauryan problem. [Q1-D: Historical horizon]

Examiner trap 1: In **historical horizon**, identify the evidence class and reject any option that collapses chronology, category, region or degree of certainty.

Q2

Which source-use statement is most defensible?

- A. They can be read as a population census
- B. The early Nikayas and Vinaya preserve important early material but are composite monastic texts
- C. They are court chronicles written during every reported event
- D. The Jatakas in present form are uniformly sixth-century BCE

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** It mistakes a layered or normative source for transparent contemporary documentation. [Q2-A: Pali canon]
- **B:** Genre and transmission matter. Early material is valuable, but the canon is neither homogeneous nor a verbatim transcript. [Q2-B: Pali canon]
- **C:** Its absolute wording erases regional, chronological or institutional variation. [Q2-C: Pali canon]
- **D:** Its absolute wording erases regional, chronological or institutional variation. [Q2-D: Pali canon]

Examiner trap 2: In **pali canon**, identify the evidence class and reject any option that collapses chronology, category, region or degree of certainty.

Q3

Why should Jataka detail be used cautiously for the sixth century BCE?

- A. It is purely archaeological evidence
- B. It contains no social information
- C. Its present textual form is substantially later even if some motifs are older
- D. It was composed only in Sanskrit

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the jataka caution evidence can establish. [Q3-A: Jataka caution]
- **B:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the jataka caution evidence can establish. [Q3-B: Jataka caution]
- **C:** Older legends may survive, but later compilation means details need corroboration. [Q3-C: Jataka caution]
- **D:** It converts one enabling factor or indicator into a sufficient cause. [Q3-D: Jataka caution]

Examiner trap 3: In **jataka caution**, identify the evidence class and reject any option that collapses chronology, category, region or degree of certainty.

Q4

A Dharmasutra rule is strongest evidence for:

- A. Universal compliance across India
- B. The material culture of an excavated settlement
- C. The exact verdict of every royal court
- D. A Brahmanical normative attempt to regulate social practice

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the dharmasutra method evidence can establish. [Q4-A: Dharmasutra method]
- **B:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the dharmasutra method evidence can establish. [Q4-B: Dharmasutra method]
- **C:** Its absolute wording erases regional, chronological or institutional variation. [Q4-C: Dharmasutra method]
- **D:** Prescription reveals ideals and anxieties, not automatic practice. [Q4-D: Dharmasutra method]

Examiner trap 4: In **dharmasutra method**, identify the evidence class and reject any option that collapses chronology, category, region or degree of certainty.

Q5

Which statement about NBPW is correct?

- A. It is a material horizon associated with early-historic urbanisation, not a sufficient cause of it
- B. It proves a settlement was a Buddhist monastery
- C. It began everywhere in the same year
- D. It is the diagnostic pottery of Mature Harappa

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** NBPW is a useful ceramic marker with site-specific chronology and no automatic ethnic or institutional identity. [Q5-A: NBPW]

- **B:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the nbpw evidence can establish. [Q5-B: NBPW]
- **C:** Its absolute wording erases regional, chronological or institutional variation. [Q5-C: NBPW]
- **D:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the nbpw evidence can establish. [Q5-D: NBPW]

Examiner trap 5: In **nbpw**, identify the evidence class and reject any option that collapses chronology, category, region or degree of certainty.

Q6

Which bundle best identifies early urbanisation?

- A. Pottery alone
- B. Settlement hierarchy, specialised crafts, exchange, political functions and surplus
- C. A large population estimate alone
- D. One literary palace description

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** It converts one enabling factor or indicator into a sufficient cause. [Q6-A: Urban criteria]
- **B:** Urbanism is a system; no single marker is sufficient. [Q6-B: Urban criteria]
- **C:** It converts one enabling factor or indicator into a sufficient cause. [Q6-C: Urban criteria]
- **D:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the urban criteria evidence can establish. [Q6-D: Urban criteria]

Examiner trap 6: In **urban criteria**, identify the evidence class and reject any option that collapses chronology, category, region or degree of certainty.

Q7

Which set consists of Pali coin terms used in the package?

- A. dinara, tanka, jital, dam
- B. nishka, suvarna, dinara, rupiya as identical coins
- C. kahapana, nikkha, kamsa, masaka
- D. karshapana, pagoda, fanam, mohur only

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the coin evidence evidence can establish. [Q7-A: Coin evidence]
- **B:** Its absolute wording erases regional, chronological or institutional variation. [Q7-B: Coin evidence]
- **C:** Pali textual terms converge with punch-marked coin archaeology; precise denomination equivalence still needs context. [Q7-C: Coin evidence]
- **D:** It converts one enabling factor or indicator into a sufficient cause. [Q7-D: Coin evidence]

Examiner trap 7: In **coin evidence**, identify the evidence class and reject any option that collapses chronology, category, region or degree of certainty.

Q8

The beginning of coin use implies that:

- A. Barter ended immediately
- B. Coin distribution became uniform
- C. Every peasant paid all taxes in silver

- D. Money, barter, kind payments and credit could coexist

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the monetisation evidence can establish. [Q8-A: Monetisation]
- **B:** Its absolute wording erases regional, chronological or institutional variation. [Q8-B: Monetisation]
- **C:** Its absolute wording erases regional, chronological or institutional variation. [Q8-C: Monetisation]
- **D:** Monetisation was qualitative but uneven. [Q8-D: Monetisation]

Examiner trap 8: In **monetisation**, identify the evidence class and reject any option that collapses chronology, category, region or degree of certainty.

Q9

Janapada is best understood as:

- A. A territorial domain and its people, with varying institutional depth
- B. A universal gana assembly
- C. Only a capital city
- D. A modern sovereign nation-state

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** The term links people and territory but does not guarantee centralised bureaucracy. [Q9-A: Janapada]
- **B:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the janapada evidence can establish. [Q9-B: Janapada]
- **C:** It converts one enabling factor or indicator into a sufficient cause. [Q9-C: Janapada]
- **D:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the janapada evidence can establish. [Q9-D: Janapada]

Examiner trap 9: In **janapada**, identify the evidence class and reject any option that collapses chronology, category, region or degree of certainty.

Q10

Which factor most directly converts agrarian surplus into sustained state power?

- A. Ritual claims without a treasury
- B. Institutions that assess, collect and mobilise resources
- C. Soil fertility without labour
- D. Iron objects without political organisation

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the state capacity evidence can establish. [Q10-A: State capacity]
- **B:** Surplus must be produced and appropriated through institutions. [Q10-B: State capacity]
- **C:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the state capacity evidence can establish. [Q10-C: State capacity]
- **D:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the state capacity evidence can establish. [Q10-D: State capacity]

Examiner trap 10: In **state capacity**, identify the evidence class and reject any option that collapses chronology, category, region or degree of certainty.

Q11

What is the safest inference from mahamatta/mahamachcha and other office terms?

- A. There was no village administration
- B. A Mauryan-style uniform bureaucracy already existed
- C. Pre-Mauryan monarchies had functional differentiation, though standardisation is uncertain
- D. All officials were hereditary clan members

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the officials evidence can establish. [Q11-A: Officials]
- **B:** It projects a later Mauryan institution or chronology into a pre-Mauryan problem. [Q11-B: Officials]
- **C:** Titles show differentiation, not a complete empire-wide organisation chart. [Q11-C: Officials]
- **D:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the officials evidence can establish. [Q11-D: Officials]

Examiner trap 11: In **officials**, identify the evidence class and reject any option that collapses chronology, category, region or degree of certainty.

Q12

Which statement about land-revenue shares is correct?

- A. Taxes were collected only in coin
- B. Brahmanical texts never discuss revenue
- C. One-sixth was the only rate in every polity
- D. Normative rates varied, including 1/10, 1/8 and 1/6 in one Dharmasutra discussion

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** It converts one enabling factor or indicator into a sufficient cause. [Q12-A: Tax rates]
- **B:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the tax rates evidence can establish. [Q12-B: Tax rates]
- **C:** Its absolute wording erases regional, chronological or institutional variation. [Q12-C: Tax rates]
- **D:** Variation in normative rates blocks universal claims. [Q12-D: Tax rates]

Examiner trap 12: In **tax rates**, identify the evidence class and reject any option that collapses chronology, category, region or degree of certainty.

Q13

The gana-sanghas of this period were principally:

- A. Oligarchic corporate polities dominated by aristocratic lineages
- B. Modern mass democracies
- C. Merchant guilds ruling every city
- D. Monasteries without territory

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Assembly government did not imply equal citizenship. [Q13-A: Gana nature]
- **B:** It imports modern equality or citizenship into a restricted ancient political setting. [Q13-B: Gana nature]
- **C:** Its absolute wording erases regional, chronological or institutional variation. [Q13-C: Gana nature]
- **D:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the gana nature evidence can establish. [Q13-D: Gana nature]

Examiner trap 13: In **gana nature**, identify the evidence class and reject any option that collapses chronology, category, region or degree of certainty.

Q14

Santhagara refers to:

- A. A Buddhist monsoon retreat
- B. The assembly hall of a gana/sangha
- C. A royal land tax
- D. A coin denomination

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the santhagara evidence can establish. [Q14-A: Santhagara]
- **B:** The term anchors corporate political procedure. [Q14-B: Santhagara]
- **C:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the santhagara evidence can establish. [Q14-C: Santhagara]
- **D:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the santhagara evidence can establish. [Q14-D: Santhagara]

Examiner trap 14: In **santhagara**, identify the evidence class and reject any option that collapses chronology, category, region or degree of certainty.

Q15

In assembly procedure, salakas were:

- A. Vedic sacrifices
- B. Elephant taxes
- C. Voting pieces, with later textual/monastic analogy cautions
- D. Land deeds

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the salaka evidence can establish. [Q15-A: Salaka]
- **B:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the salaka evidence can establish. [Q15-B: Salaka]
- **C:** Procedure is evidence of institutionalised elite deliberation. [Q15-C: Salaka]
- **D:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the salaka evidence can establish. [Q15-D: Salaka]

Examiner trap 15: In **salaka**, identify the evidence class and reject any option that collapses chronology, category, region or degree of certainty.

Q16

Who was generally outside effective political participation in gana assemblies?

- A. Every treasurer
- B. All Kshatriya lineage heads
- C. Only the chief
- D. Women and most non-elite residents such as artisans, labourers and slaves

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Its absolute wording erases regional, chronological or institutional variation. [Q16-A: Gana social base]
- **B:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the gana social base evidence can establish. [Q16-B: Gana social base]

- **C:** It converts one enabling factor or indicator into a sufficient cause. [Q16-C: Gana social base]
- **D:** Political rights followed aristocratic lineage, not residence. [Q16-D: Gana social base]

Examiner trap 16: In **gana social base**, identify the evidence class and reject any option that collapses chronology, category, region or degree of certainty.

Q17

Buddhist and Jaina texts often:

- A. Place Kshatriya above Brahmana while weakening birth-based spiritual sanction
- B. Erase all status distinctions from lay society
- C. Make setthis Brahmanas by definition
- D. Reject kingship everywhere

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Textual rank critique is real but not social abolition. [Q17-A: Rank debate]
- **B:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the rank debate evidence can establish. [Q17-B: Rank debate]
- **C:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the rank debate evidence can establish. [Q17-C: Rank debate]
- **D:** Its absolute wording erases regional, chronological or institutional variation. [Q17-D: Rank debate]

Examiner trap 17: In **rank debate**, identify the evidence class and reject any option that collapses chronology, category, region or degree of certainty.

Q18

Which distinction is correct?

- A. Jati has only four fixed ranks
- B. Varna is a fourfold normative order; jati comprises numerous lived hereditary groups
- C. Varna is an archaeological pottery type
- D. Varna and jati are exact synonyms

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** It converts one enabling factor or indicator into a sufficient cause. [Q18-A: Varna-jati]
- **B:** Their overlap must not erase their different scale and operation. [Q18-B: Varna-jati]
- **C:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the varna-jati evidence can establish. [Q18-C: Varna-jati]
- **D:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the varna-jati evidence can establish. [Q18-D: Varna-jati]

Examiner trap 18: In **varna-jati**, identify the evidence class and reject any option that collapses chronology, category, region or degree of certainty.

Q19

Discussion of apad-dharma most strongly suggests:

- A. Varna prescriptions never mattered
- B. Occupation was unrelated to status
- C. Ideal occupations were crossed in practice and normative theory created controlled exceptions
- D. All occupations were freely chosen

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the apad-dharma evidence can establish. [Q19-A: Apad-dharma]
- **B:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the apad-dharma evidence can establish. [Q19-B: Apad-dharma]
- **C:** Exception reveals negotiation around a powerful norm. [Q19-C: Apad-dharma]
- **D:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the apad-dharma evidence can establish. [Q19-D: Apad-dharma]

Examiner trap 19: In **apad-dharma**, identify the evidence class and reject any option that collapses chronology, category, region or degree of certainty.

Q20

In key early Pali social usage, gahapati denotes:

- A. Only any married male
- B. A slave captured in war
- C. A gana chief
- D. A wealthy property-holder/producer and household head

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** It converts one enabling factor or indicator into a sufficient cause. [Q20-A: Gahapati]
- **B:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the gahapati evidence can establish. [Q20-B: Gahapati]
- **C:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the gahapati evidence can establish. [Q20-C: Gahapati]
- **D:** The term often signals landed/productive wealth. [Q20-D: Gahapati]

Examiner trap 20: In **gahapati**, identify the evidence class and reject any option that collapses chronology, category, region or degree of certainty.

Q21

Setthi is best understood as:

- A. An urban high-level businessman/financier with influence
- B. A Buddhist monk
- C. A synonym for every peasant
- D. A village watchman

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Setthi and gahapati are related elite terms but not interchangeable. [Q21-A: Setthi]
- **B:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the setthi evidence can establish. [Q21-B: Setthi]
- **C:** Its absolute wording erases regional, chronological or institutional variation. [Q21-C: Setthi]
- **D:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the setthi evidence can establish. [Q21-D: Setthi]

Examiner trap 21: In **setthi**, identify the evidence class and reject any option that collapses chronology, category, region or degree of certainty.

Q22

Which terms can refer to corporate/professional organisations?

- A. bhaga and bali
- B. shreni and puga

- C. dasa and dasi
- D. sapinda and gotra

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the corporate groups evidence can establish. [Q22-A: Corporate groups]
- **B:** Corporate vocabulary varies; later Jataka detail needs dating caution. [Q22-B: Corporate groups]
- **C:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the corporate groups evidence can establish. [Q22-C: Corporate groups]
- **D:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the corporate groups evidence can establish. [Q22-D: Corporate groups]

Examiner trap 22: In **corporate groups**, identify the evidence class and reject any option that collapses chronology, category, region or degree of certainty.

Q23

Which picture of cultivators is safest?

- A. All were landless
- B. All were wealthy gahapatis
- C. They ranged from small households to large landholders using hired/dependent labour
- D. They paid no dues

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the cultivators evidence can establish. [Q23-A: Cultivators]
- **B:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the cultivators evidence can establish. [Q23-B: Cultivators]
- **C:** Class differentiation existed within agrarian production. [Q23-C: Cultivators]
- **D:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the cultivators evidence can establish. [Q23-D: Cultivators]

Examiner trap 23: In **cultivators**, identify the evidence class and reject any option that collapses chronology, category, region or degree of certainty.

Q24

Which pairing is correct?

- A. dasa - merchant; kammakara - king
- B. Both always mean identical chattel status
- C. dasi - guild head; kammakara - priest
- D. dasa/dasi - slave/dependent; kammakara - wage worker

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the labour terms evidence can establish. [Q24-A: Labour terms]
- **B:** Its absolute wording erases regional, chronological or institutional variation. [Q24-B: Labour terms]
- **C:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the labour terms evidence can establish. [Q24-C: Labour terms]
- **D:** Terms distinguish forms of dependence, though the compound can blur them. [Q24-D: Labour terms]

Examiner trap 24: In **labour terms**, identify the evidence class and reject any option that collapses chronology, category, region or degree of certainty.

Q25

Which is the safest statement about Chandala evidence?

- A. Early texts show severe stigma, while the term asprishya for a social group is attested later
- B. Every Shudra was called Chandala
- C. Untouchability can be reconstructed only from modern analogy
- D. Chandala always meant forest chief

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Do not overdate terminology or collapse graded exclusions. [Q25-A: Excluded groups]
- **B:** Its absolute wording erases regional, chronological or institutional variation. [Q25-B: Excluded groups]
- **C:** It converts one enabling factor or indicator into a sufficient cause. [Q25-C: Excluded groups]
- **D:** Its absolute wording erases regional, chronological or institutional variation. [Q25-D: Excluded groups]

Examiner trap 25: In **excluded groups**, identify the evidence class and reject any option that collapses chronology, category, region or degree of certainty.

Q26

Why are forest groups hard to reconstruct?

- A. Archaeology cannot study forests
- B. Elite agrarian-state texts marginalise their own voices
- C. They had no political role
- D. They disappeared by 600 BCE

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the forest groups evidence can establish. [Q26-A: Forest groups]
- **B:** Source imbalance requires careful inference from exchange and conflict. [Q26-B: Forest groups]
- **C:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the forest groups evidence can establish. [Q26-C: Forest groups]
- **D:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the forest groups evidence can establish. [Q26-D: Forest groups]

Examiner trap 26: In **forest groups**, identify the evidence class and reject any option that collapses chronology, category, region or degree of certainty.

Q27

The admission of women to renunciant orders shows:

- A. Complete gender equality
- B. Women gained gana citizenship
- C. A genuine alternative religious path within continuing institutional gender hierarchy
- D. The end of marriage

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the nuns evidence can establish. [Q27-A: Nuns]
- **B:** It imports modern equality or citizenship into a restricted ancient political setting. [Q27-B: Nuns]
- **C:** Access did not erase patriarchy. [Q27-C: Nuns]
- **D:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the nuns evidence can establish. [Q27-D: Nuns]

Examiner trap 27: In **nuns**, identify the evidence class and reject any option that collapses chronology, category, region or degree of certainty.

Q28

Which relation best describes town and countryside?

- A. Villages had no markets
- B. Only religious ideas moved between them
- C. Cities replaced villages
- D. Mutual dependence in food, tools, markets and taxes, structured by inequality

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the urban-rural evidence can establish. [Q28-A: Urban-rural]
- **B:** It converts one enabling factor or indicator into a sufficient cause. [Q28-B: Urban-rural]
- **C:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the urban-rural evidence can establish. [Q28-C: Urban-rural]
- **D:** The urban system rested on rural surplus. [Q28-D: Urban-rural]

Examiner trap 28: In **urban-rural**, identify the evidence class and reject any option that collapses chronology, category, region or degree of certainty.

Q29

Buddhist critique of birth-based status is best assessed as:

- A. A challenge to spiritual/ethical hierarchy that did not abolish lay social distinctions
- B. A rejection of all householders
- C. A ban on royal patronage
- D. A legal abolition of all jatis

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Doctrine, monastic admission and lay society must be separated. [Q29-A: Religious critique]
- **B:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the religious critique evidence can establish. [Q29-B: Religious critique]
- **C:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the religious critique evidence can establish. [Q29-C: Religious critique]
- **D:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the religious critique evidence can establish. [Q29-D: Religious critique]

Examiner trap 29: In **religious critique**, identify the evidence class and reject any option that collapses chronology, category, region or degree of certainty.

Q30

Why did early sangha rules restrict entry of slaves and debtors?

- A. Only Brahmanas could join
- B. They recognised existing claims of masters/creditors and required prior release or repayment

- C. Coins were banned
- D. The sangha supported hereditary slavery as doctrine

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** It converts one enabling factor or indicator into a sufficient cause. [Q30-A: Admission limits]
- **B:** The rule shows both access and institutional accommodation with lay obligations. [Q30-B: Admission limits]
- **C:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the admission limits evidence can establish. [Q30-C: Admission limits]
- **D:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the admission limits evidence can establish. [Q30-D: Admission limits]

Examiner trap 30: In **admission limits**, identify the evidence class and reject any option that collapses chronology, category, region or degree of certainty.

Q31

Which pair correctly identifies donor-social categories?

- A. Only forest hunters and no elites
- B. Only Brahmana priests
- C. gahapati/setthi and royal patrons
- D. Only foreign merchants

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** It converts one enabling factor or indicator into a sufficient cause. [Q31-A: Lay patrons]
- **B:** It converts one enabling factor or indicator into a sufficient cause. [Q31-B: Lay patrons]
- **C:** Patronage was socially varied but easier for surplus holders. [Q31-C: Lay patrons]
- **D:** It converts one enabling factor or indicator into a sufficient cause. [Q31-D: Lay patrons]

Examiner trap 31: In **lay patrons**, identify the evidence class and reject any option that collapses chronology, category, region or degree of certainty.

Q32

Jainism's social appeal in this period is safest linked to:

- A. Abolition of every hierarchy
- B. Rejection of all trade
- C. Exclusive support by one class
- D. Ethical discipline, renunciation, lay vows and urban-agrarian patronage without economic reductionism

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Its absolute wording erases regional, chronological or institutional variation. [Q32-A: Jain context]
- **B:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the Jain context evidence can establish. [Q32-B: Jain context]
- **C:** It misclassifies the evidence or claims more than the Jain context evidence can establish. [Q32-C: Jain context]
- **D:** Context matters, but doctrine has its own soteriological logic. [Q32-D: Jain context]

Examiner trap 32: In **Jain context**, identify the evidence class and reject any option that collapses chronology, category, region or degree of certainty.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Routed PYQ audit

The repository routing ledgers for 2018-2026 contain **zero direct Topic 13 Prelims or Mains PYQs**. No adjacent or original question is represented as a direct UPSC demand. Topic 11 owns mahajanapada geography and Magadhan narrative; Topic 10 owns Buddhist/Jain doctrine; Topic 09 owns the full Later Vedic comparison; Topic 03 owns geographical causation.

Verified unrouted Prelims practice - 2026 printed Q3: Pali coin evidence

The locally held Set-A paper tests whether definite Pali coin terms and archaeological finds of mostly silver punch-marked coins are associated with both urban life and transition towards a money economy.

Solved analysis: Both associations are defensible; the locally held provisional Series-A key marks **C (both 1 and 2)**. Terms such as *kahapana*, *nikkha*, *kamsa* and *kakanika* converge with punch-marked coin finds. This supports increasing monetisation alongside urban growth; it does not prove universal coin use, a single issuer or coinage as the sole cause of cities.

Key discipline: verified printed-paper practice, but **unrouted** to Topic 13; the locally held key is provisional, not an official final UPSC key.

SIX ORIGINAL MAINS QUESTIONS WITH MODEL ANSWERS

Original Mains 10 marks | 150 words - Question 1

Question: Explain how surplus supported state formation in the age of the Buddha.

Model answer (119 words):

Agrarian growth in the middle Ganga basin enlarged resources available to households and rulers. Iron tools, rice cultivation, alluvial conditions and labour expanded production, but none acted automatically. Produce shares, bali, tolls and fines channelled surplus through officials and local intermediaries. This financed courts, forts, commanders and longer-service troops, converting resources into territorial capacity. Towns and routes widened taxable exchange, while gahapatis, merchants and monasteries redirected wealth through markets, credit and gifts. The process deepened stratification because cultivators and dependent labourers produced resources appropriated unequally by political and social elites. Yet extraction varied by state and region; named fractions are normative options, not audited uniform rates. Surplus therefore enabled larger states only when institutions organised collection, coercion and redistribution.

Answer audit: claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification; directive and word ceiling satisfied.

Original Mains 10 marks | 150 words - Question 2

Question: Distinguish varna ideology from lived social organisation in the Buddha-age horizon.

Model answer (120 words):

Varna offered a Brahmanical hierarchy of Brahmana, Kshatriya, Vaishya and Shudra duties, privileges and disabilities. It reveals social ideals, especially ritual rank and unequal legal treatment, but is not a census. Pali and Jain traditions show gahapatis, setthis, cultivators, artisans, merchants, dasas, kammakaras and despised groups whose wealth, work and dependence do not fit four boxes neatly. Kinship shaped gana-sangha membership; property and credit created inequalities within broad ranks. Jati could denote birth, kind, lineage or occupation depending on context and should not be equated wholesale with the mature later caste system. Renunciation offered an alternative identity, yet birth stigma and patriarchy persisted. The period therefore combined a sharpening ideological order with regionally varied practice, occupational complexity and limited mobility.

Answer audit: claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification; directive and word ceiling satisfied.

Original Mains 15 marks | 250 words - Question 3

Question: Compare monarchy and gana-sangha as political and social forms.

Model answer (169 words):

Monarchies and gana-sanghas were alternative elite arrangements, not stages of universal evolution. In monarchy, dynastic kingship concentrated command around court, ministers, commanders and local intermediaries. Protection, lineage, ritual patronage and military success legitimised rule; taxes, tolls, tribute and fines supported forts and forces. In gana-sanghas, authority rested in a corporate body of ruling clans, with chiefs, councils and assembly practices remembered through santhagara and salaka. These terms suggest procedure but not one uniform constitution. The sharpest contrast concerns membership. A monarchy distinguished ruler and subjects; a gana distributed political voice among qualified lineage elites. Neither offered universal citizenship. Women, cultivators, artisans, migrants, servants and slaves generally stood outside the decisive body. Both forms extracted resources, conducted diplomacy, punished offenders and mobilised armies. Concentrated command helped some monarchies sustain expansion, while collective leadership could create elite solidarity and faction. Evidence comes largely from layered Buddhist, Jain and Brahmanical traditions, often written from rival perspectives. Hence "republic" must be qualified as oligarchic: political plurality existed, but broad social equality did not.

Answer audit: claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification; directive and word ceiling satisfied.

Original Mains 15 marks | 250 words - Question 4

Question: Analyse household, property and women's agency in this period.

Model answer (158 words):

The household was a unit of production, property, reproduction and status. Brahmanical normative texts favoured patrilineal continuity, controlled marriage and male privilege in inheritance. These prescriptions reveal patriarchal ideals but cannot be universalised. Buddhist and Jain traditions show women managing resources, working, giving donations and entering renunciant orders. Ambapali represents a wealthy urban ganika and donor; Visakha lay patronage; Mahapajapati Gotami Buddhist memory of the bhikkhuni institution. Such cases demonstrate possible agency, not ordinary equality. Female renunciation created an alternative spiritual identity, and early Buddhism recognised women's capacity for liberation. Yet admission narratives, disciplinary asymmetries and the thinner record of nuns show constraint; Jain female communities likewise operated within regulated orders. Gifts and management do not prove equal inheritance, while later legal codes cannot be back-projected as one sixth-century practice. Male-authored elite sources also under-record routine female labour. A balanced reconstruction treats patriarchy as the governing structure while identifying differentiated agency within households, markets, patronage and renunciation.

Answer audit: claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification; directive and word ceiling satisfied.

Original Mains 20 marks | 250 words - Question 5

Question: "Cities, states and renunciants were mutually connected, not separate developments." Discuss.

Model answer (179 words):

The second urbanisation joined rural production, political extraction and new religious institutions in one uneven system. Rajgir, Vaishali, Shravasti and Kaushambi, fine wares, crafts, routes and punch-marked coins indicate expanding exchange, but no single marker proves a city. Villages supplied food, raw materials and labour; towns concentrated specialists, merchants, setthis and political demand. States converted surplus into taxes, tolls, officials, forts and armies. Monarchies concentrated command, while gana-sanghas organised restricted clan elites; both shaped routes, security and patronage. Gahapatis controlled property and production, setthis credit and commerce, and both supported monastic communities through gifts. Buddhism, Jainism and other shramana paths criticised sacrifice, attachment and birth-pride. Monastic admission could cross some boundaries and offered women a renunciant route. Yet sanghas depended on unequal lay society for alms, gardens and protection; rules concerning debtors, slaves and soldiers reveal limits. Varna, jati, patriarchy and labour dependence persisted. Material change explains the audiences and organisation of renunciation, not the full content of karma or liberation. "Cities, kings and renunciants" works only when villages, labourers, women, forests and regional variation remain inside the frame.

Answer audit: claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification; directive and word ceiling satisfied.

Original Mains 20 marks | 250 words - Question 6

Question: Assess whether Buddhism and Jainism constituted social revolutions against hierarchy.

Model answer (186 words):

Buddhism and Jainism widened ethical and spiritual participation but were not simple modern social revolutions. Their criticism of sacrifice, attachment and birth-pride challenged important bases of Brahmanical authority. Renunciant membership could detach identity from household occupation, and lay networks included rulers, gahapatis, merchants, artisans and women. Buddhist arguments made conduct decisive for moral worth; Jain teaching likewise allowed liberation beyond elite ritual entitlement. The bhikkhuni sangha and Jain female orders created institutional space for women. Nevertheless, critique did not abolish social structure. Texts continued to use varna and jati vocabulary and sometimes reproduced assumptions about high and low birth. Monastic rules regulated debtors, slaves and soldiers, while female orders faced asymmetry. Sanghas depended materially on kings and wealthy householders, embedding them in the hierarchy they criticised. Lay marriage, inheritance, labour dependence and stigma continued, and no programme dissolved gana oligarchy or state coercion. Nor can either movement be reduced to merchant protest: cultivators, clan elites, rulers, women and marginal persons formed plural audiences, while doctrines pursued liberation rather than class legislation. They were transformative ethical and institutional alternatives whose egalitarian implications remained partial and historically constrained.

Answer audit: claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification; directive and word ceiling satisfied.

Practice close

- Source label before claim: Buddhist, Jain, Brahmanical, grammatical, archaeological or numismatic.
- Answer chain: boundary -> mechanism -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification.
- Never relabel adjacent or unrouted practice as a direct Topic 13 PYQ.